



Hitting the ground

US Marines at Khe Sanh scramble to take shelter from incoming fire. The Marines endured up to 1,300 rounds of mortar and artillery each day, mainly from Soviet-made 122 mm rockets and 120 mm mortars.

Second onslaught

As the Tet Offensive exploded across the rest of South Vietnam on January 30 and 31, the area around Khe Sanh remained eerily calm. It was not until February 5 that communist forces began to test US defenses again, in a fierce assault against Marines on Hill 861 and 861A that was repelled via bloody hand-to-hand combat. Two days later, thousands of ground troops from the NVA's 304th Division attacked Lang Vei, supported by light tanks. By this time the defense of the Special Forces camp included 24 Green Berets, a handful of Royal Laotian troops, and some 900 Montagnard militia.

By late afternoon, the NVA had broken through the perimeter and was overrunning the camp. With the NVA in control of the road and nightfall closing in, relief by ground or air from Khe Sanh was impossible. Faced with certain defeat and probably slaughter, the Green Beret commander called for a blistering artillery barrage to be directed on his own base and ordered his troops to retreat into the jungle. Out of around 1,000 defenders, fewer than 100 reached safety in Khe Sanh or elsewhere.

At sunrise on February 8, the situation looked bleak for the US soldiers at Khe Sanh. The nearby Special Forces camp at Lang Vei had been utterly destroyed with great loss, the main firebase was surrounded by tens of thousands of communist troops, and Route 9 to the coast was blocked. Although the Tet Offensive had been blunted nearly everywhere else in the South by early February, there was no sign of a communist retreat from the warren of bunkers and zigzag trenches around Khe Sanh. Under cover of darkness, foul weather, and artillery attacks, Giap's forces continued to inch closer to the American lines.